

DELHI *to* MANALI

The Complete Traveller's Blueprint

8 DAYS

Full Itinerary

3 REGIONS

Delhi · Manali · Sissu

50+ GEMS

Hidden Places

Hotels & Booking Links • Day-by-Day Schedule • Hidden Restaurants • Scam Warnings • Budget Guide

"India is not a country. It is an experience."

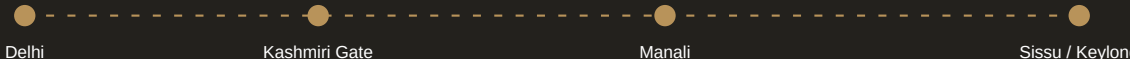


TABLE OF CONTENTS

BEFORE YOU ARRIVE — Essential India Prep	3
ARRIVAL IN DELHI — Aerocity & First Night	4
DAY 1 — Delhi: Old City & Mughal Grandeur	5
DAY 2 — Delhi: South Delhi & Modern India	6
DELHI FOOD GUIDE — Where to Eat & What to Try	7
BOOKING YOUR BUS — Delhi → Manali (Night Bus)	8
DAY 3 — Manali Arrival & Old Manali	9
DAY 4 — Manali: Waterfalls, Markets & The River	10
MANALI FOOD GUIDE — Local Eats & Cafes	11
DAY 5 — Sissu & Keylong Day Trip	12
DAY 6 — Return to Delhi	13
INDIA SURVIVAL GUIDE — Costs, Scams & Safety	14
DO's & DON'Ts — The Honest India Manual	15
PACKING LIST — What You Actually Need	16
BUDGET BREAKDOWN — Full Trip Cost	17

"The best journeys in life are those that answer questions you never thought to ask."

BEFORE YOU ARRIVE — Essential India Prep

Read this page before you book anything. It will save you real money and real stress.

VISA & ENTRY

e-Tourist Visa (eTV) — Apply online at indianvisaonline.gov.in at least 4 days before travel. Most nationalities qualify. Cost: USD 25–80 depending on your country. You will receive it by email — print it or save it offline.

❑ IMPORTANT

Do NOT apply through third-party websites charging \$150+. The official Indian government portal charges a fraction of that. Any other site is a scam.

BEST TIME TO VISIT THIS ROUTE

Best Season

May – October

Manali roads fully open

Avoid

Nov – Mar for Manali

Rohtang Pass may close

Delhi Peak

Oct – Feb

Cool and clear skies

❑ Monsoon Warning (July–Aug)

Manali experiences heavy rain and occasional landslides in July–August. Roads to Sissu can be blocked for 1–2 days. Check road status at: himachal.nic.in/roads before your trip.

HEALTH & VACCINATIONS

Recommended vaccines: ensure routine vaccinations are up to date. Anti-malarial pills are only needed if visiting jungle areas — not required for this route.

Altitude sickness at Manali (2,050m) / Sissu (3,100m): You will likely feel fine, but take it easy on your first day. Drink extra water. Avoid alcohol your first night. If you get headaches, descend — do not push through it.

MONEY & PAYMENTS

Currency

Indian Rupee (INR)

1 USD ≈ 96 INR (2025)

ATMs

Available in Delhi & Manali

Less common in Sissu/Keylong

Cards

Accepted in cities

Carry cash in Manali mountains

❑ Pro Tip: Cash

Withdraw INR 10,000–15,000 in Delhi before leaving for Manali. ATMs in higher altitude areas run out of cash or have low limits. International cards charge fees — Wise or Revolut cards are best for zero forex fees.

SIM CARD

Get a local SIM at Delhi Airport (Arrivals Hall). Recommended: Airtel or Jio. Cost: 300–600 **inr** for 28-day plan with 1.5GB/day data. You will need your passport and a passport photo. It takes 30–60 minutes to activate.

ARRIVAL IN DELHI — Aerocity & First Night

Indira Gandhi International Airport (DEL) is one of Asia's busiest airports. This page covers everything from the moment you land to checking into your hotel.

STEP 1: ARRIVING AT IGI AIRPORT

Immigration E-Visa Counter

Look for the e-Visa lane — it is separate from the regular foreigner queue and usually faster. Have your visa print-out, return ticket, and hotel booking ready to show.

Baggage Collect & Customs

Customs is straightforward. If you have electronics above personal use limits, declare them. Normally you will walk straight through the green channel.

Exit Arrivals Hall

You will be approached by dozens of taxi touts the moment you exit. Walk past all of them. Do not say yes to anyone offering "special price" transport. Scroll down for the safe way.

❑ Airport Taxi Scam — Very Common

Taxi drivers outside arrivals WILL approach you and quote **inr 2,000–4,000** for a short trip. The actual fare should be **₹300–600**. Always use the Uber or Ola app, or the prepaid taxi counter **INSIDE** the terminal. Never negotiate with random drivers at the exit.

STEP 2: GETTING TO YOUR HOTEL

Best option: Uber/Ola — Download the app before landing (on airport WiFi). Book from inside the terminal. Fare to Aerocity: **₹80–150**. Fare to South Delhi: **₹400–700**. Wait time: 5–10 minutes.

Airport Metro: Terminal 3 is connected to the metro (Orange Line). Fare to Connaught Place: **₹60**. Fast and cheap but NOT recommended with large luggage — the stations are crowded and confusing for first-time visitors.

WHERE TO STAY — NIGHT 1 RECOMMENDATIONS

Book through MakeMyTrip (makemytrip.com) — Reliable INR prices, easy cancellation, and customer support in English.

Aerocity (Near Airport) **BEST for first night**

3,500–7,000/night

Holiday Inn Express Aerocity, Ibis Delhi Aerocity, Lemon Tree Premier

Perfect if arriving late. 5 min from airport. Safe, clean, international standard.

South Delhi (Hauz Khas / Defence Colony) **BEST for exploring Delhi**

4,000–9,000/night

The Mango Tree, Devna Villa, Lutyens Bungalow

Beautiful neighbourhoods, excellent restaurants nearby, safer for solo travellers.

Paharganj (Budget) **Backpacker hub**

800–2,500/night

Hotel Smyle Inn, Metropolis Tourist Home

Central, near New Delhi Railway Station. Fine for budget travellers but can be chaotic and noisy.

DAY 1 — Delhi: Old City & Mughal Grandeur

Transport

Hired cab for the day

OLA rental: ₹1,200–1,800

Difficulty

Moderate

Crowded but manageable

Weather Tip

Start by 8:30 AM

Avoid midday heat

We strongly recommend booking a day cab through OLA Outstation or a local driver (ask your hotel). Delhi is big, the distances between sites are real, and the metro is genuinely confusing for first-time visitors. A dedicated cab for the day costs ₹1,200–1,800 and removes 80% of your stress.

THE SCHEDULE

8:30 AM

Jama Masjid — India's Largest Mosque

One of the largest mosques in Asia, built by Shah Jahan in 1656. 25,000 people can pray here simultaneously. Climb the southern minaret for a sweeping view of Old Delhi. Dress modestly — scarves available at entrance.

300 (tower climb) | FREE entry

9:30 AM

Red Fort (Lal Qila)

A UNESCO World Heritage Site and the political heart of Mughal India. The Diwan-i-Aam (Hall of Public Audiences) and Diwan-i-Khas (Hall of Private Audiences) are stunning. Allow 90 minutes minimum.

600 (foreign nationals) | Opens 9:30 AM

11:30 AM

Chandni Chowk — The Real Delhi

One of the oldest and busiest markets in India. Walk down the main street, turn into the lanes, and get completely lost. Find the Paranthe Wali Gali (Famous Paratha Lane) for breakfast.

30–80 for breakfast

1:00 PM

Lunch in Old Delhi

Karim's Restaurant (since 1913) — one of the most famous non-vegetarian restaurants in India. Their mutton korma and seekh kebabs are legendary. Or try Al Jawahar for a slightly quieter experience.

400–700 per person

2:30 PM

Humayun's Tomb

The architectural precursor to the Taj Mahal. Built in 1565, it was the first garden-tomb on the Indian subcontinent. Serene, beautiful, and far less crowded than Agra. The Nila Gumbad nearby is equally photogenic.

600 (foreign nationals)

4:30 PM

Lodhi Garden

A beautiful 90-acre park containing 15th-century tombs. Perfect for a golden-hour walk. Surprisingly peaceful given you're in the heart of Delhi. Locals jog, picnic, and practice yoga here.

FREE

7:00 PM

India Gate & Kartavya Path

India's war memorial, inspired by the Arc de Triomphe. The surrounding Kartavya Path (formerly Rajpath) is wide, well-lit, and beautiful at night. Canang sellers line the path — negotiate hard.

FREE

8:00 PM

Dinner — Khan Market or Hauz Khas

See the food guide on page 7 for specific restaurant recommendations. Khan Market is safe, upscale, and has excellent variety.

600–1,200 per person

☐ Tourist Price vs Local Price

At monuments, foreign national tickets are priced much higher than Indian nationals. This is legal and official — it is NOT a scam. Always buy tickets at the official Archaeological Survey of India counter, not from touts outside.

DAY 2 — Delhi: South Delhi & Modern India

Area Focus

South Delhi

Hauz Khas, Qutub, ISKCON

Vibe

Mix of old & new

Cafes, ruins, temples

Evening

Prep for overnight bus

Pack tonight

THE SCHEDULE

9:00 AM Qutub Minar Complex

The tallest brick minaret in the world (72.5 metres), built in 1193. The Iron Pillar inside the complex has stood rust-free for 1,600 years — a metallurgical mystery that still baffles scientists. Arrive early — it gets very crowded by 11 AM.

600 (foreign nationals) | 1.5 hrs

11:00 AM Hauz Khas Village

A medieval reservoir turned Delhi's hippest neighbourhood. Walk around the 13th-century water tank, explore the ruins, then wander into the narrow lanes filled with boutique shops, art galleries, and independent cafes. Far more interesting than most tourist spots.

FREE entry to ruins

1:00 PM Lunch at Hauz Khas or Green Park

See food page for recommendations. This area has excellent cafes including Yeti, The Big Chill, and several rooftop restaurants with views of the ruins.

500–1,000 per person

2:30 PM ISKCON Temple (Hare Krishna)

One of the most ornate temples in Delhi, built in white marble and Italian marble. Open to all religions. The evening aarti (prayer ceremony) is beautiful — if your timing works, attend. Clean, well-organized, AC inside.

FREE | Shoes off at entrance

4:00 PM Dilli Haat (INA)

An open-air crafts market where artisans from all 29 Indian states sell their work. Perfect for authentic souvenirs — Kashmiri shawls, Rajasthani textiles, tribal jewellery, handmade pottery. Prices are fixed, no bargaining stress.

100 entry | Goods: 300–5,000+

6:00 PM Khan Market

Delhi's most beloved upscale market. Bookshops, boutiques, bakeries, and restaurants. Buy Bisleri water here (always buy sealed bottles, ₹20–30). This is also a good place to pick up any last-minute travel supplies.

Free to browse

7:30 PM Dinner & Packing

Eat an early, light dinner. You will be boarding a night bus at 9–10 PM. Pack your bag — see packing guide on page 16. Bring a light jacket, snacks, and something to sleep in.

9:30 PM Cab to ISBT Kashmiri Gate

Book an Uber or Ola at least 30 minutes before departure. The route from South Delhi can take 45–60 minutes due to traffic. See next page for complete bus guide.

350–550 by Uber

DELHI FOOD GUIDE — Where to Eat & What to Try

"Eating in Delhi is not an optional activity. It is the activity. These recommendations are based on consistent quality, local reputation, and real traveller experience — not paid rankings."

STREET FOOD YOU MUST TRY

Chole Bhature

₹60–100

Chickpea curry with deep-fried bread. The definitive Delhi breakfast. Try at: Sita Ram Diwan Chand (Paharganj), Nagpal Chole Bhature (Kamla Nagar).

Time needed: 20 min

Paranthe Wali Gali

₹50–120/paratha

A 300-year-old lane in Chandni Chowk dedicated entirely to stuffed flatbreads. Order 2–3 varieties — aloo, paneer, or rabri (sweet). Pure experience.

Time needed: 45 min

Dahi Bhalla Papdi Chaat

₹40–80

Crispy flatbread topped with yogurt, chutneys, and spices. Best from: Bengali Sweet House (Connaught Place) or any chaat stall in Lajpat Nagar.

Time needed: 10 min

Nihari (slow-cooked meat stew)

₹200–350

A Mughal breakfast dish slow-cooked overnight. Only available in morning until stock runs out. Best at: Kallu Nihari (Matia Mahal, Old Delhi).

Time needed: Morning only

Gol Gappe / Pani Puri

₹20–40 for 6 pieces

Hollow crisp shells filled with spiced water. You get 6 pieces at a time. The vendor fills them one by one — eat immediately. Anywhere you see a street cart.

Time needed: Any time

BEST RESTAURANTS — DELHI

Karim's – Jama Masjid, Old Delhi

₹500–900/person

Mughal Non-Veg since 1913

Must try: Mutton Korma, Seekh Kebab, Shami Kebab

Indian Accent – Lodhi Estate, South Delhi

₹4,000–7,000/person

Modern Indian Fine Dining

Must try: Doda Barfi Old Fashioned, Blue Cheese Naan

Bukhara (ITC Maurya) – Chanakyapuri

₹3,500–6,000/person

North Indian Tandoor Legend

Must try: Dal Bukhara (cooked 18 hrs), Sikandari Raan

Yeti – The Himalayan Kitchen – Hauz Khas

₹600–1,000/person

Tibetan/Nepali Comfort Food

Must try: Thukpa (noodle soup), Butter chicken momos

The Big Chill – Khan Market & Hauz Khas

₹800–1,400/person

Italian Comfort Food

Must try: Tiramisu, pastas, best value in South Delhi

Paranthe Wali Gali – Chandni Chowk

₹150–300/person

Street / Heritage

Must try: 300-year-old paratha shop

Moti Mahal – Daryaganj, Old Delhi

₹800–1,500/person

North Indian | Claimed inventor of Butter Chicken

Must try: Butter Chicken (THE original), Dal Makhani

DRINKING WATER — READ THIS

❑ Never Drink Tap Water

Delhi tap water is NOT safe for foreigners. Your stomach is not acclimatised. Always buy sealed Bisleri, Kinley, or Aquafina bottles. Cost: 20 for 1L, 50 for 2L. Carry a 2L bottle with you at all times. This single habit prevents 90% of stomach issues.

❑ Chai is Safe

Street chai (tea) is boiled and completely safe. The best chai costs 10–20 and is made with spices, ginger, and full-fat milk. It is one of the great pleasures of India. Drink it every chance you get.

BOOKING YOUR BUS — Delhi to Manali Night Bus

This is the authentic way to reach Manali and how most travellers and locals do it. An overnight sleeper bus saves you a hotel night, arrives in the morning, and costs a fraction of flying.

BUS DETAILS

Journey Time 11–13 hours Departs ~9:30 PM, arrives ~8–10 AM	Distance 540 km Via NH3 (Manali Highway)	Cost ₹800–2,000 Seater to Luxury Sleeper
--	---	---

HOW TO BOOK

Book on MakeMyTrip.com or redBus.in — Both platforms show real-time seat availability with photos of the bus interiors. Book at least 3–5 days in advance during peak season (May–September).

Seater (Non-AC) Reclining seats, windows. Fine for short trips. Noisy, no sleeping comfort. Not recommended for 11 hours.	800–1,000
Sleeper (Non-AC) Individual sleeping berths, curtains. Good budget option. Gets cold in mountains at night — bring a jacket.	1,000–1,400
Luxury AC Sleeper (Volvo) Recommended. HRTC Volvo or ZingBus Luxury. USB charging, blankets, wide berths. Worth the extra cost.	1,500–2,500
ZingBus Premium Best reviewed private operator. Clean buses, good suspension, comfortable. Book directly on zingbus.com or MakeMyTrip.	1,800–2,200

THE BUS TERMINAL: ISBT KASHMIRI GATE

Inter State Bus Terminal (ISBT) Kashmiri Gate is where ALL buses to Himachal Pradesh depart from. It is large, busy, and confusing. Here is how to navigate it:

Arrival	Arrive 45 minutes early The terminal is large. You need time to find your platform. Do not arrive last minute.
Finding Bus	Look for HRTC bay or private operator Your ticket will have a platform/bay number. Confirm with terminal staff — they are usually helpful.
Your Bus	Confirm bus number before boarding Multiple buses depart at similar times. Double check the destination board AND the ticket number on your seat.
Luggage	Large bags go in the undercarriage Take your day bag inside with you. Keep valuables, phone charger, and snacks in the cabin bag.

WHAT TO PACK FOR THE BUS

In your cabin bag: Light jacket or hoodie (mountains get cold), neck pillow, earphones, 2L water bottle, snacks (biscuits, chips, dry fruit), phone + power bank, eye mask, basic medicines (Diarrhoea tablets just in case).

□ **Bus Stops for Breaks**

The driver will stop 2–3 times at highway dhabas (roadside restaurants) for 20–30 minutes. These are at roughly 1 AM, 4 AM, and 7 AM. The food at dhabas is genuinely good — hot dal, rice, rotis at any hour.

□ **Motion Sickness Warning**

The last 2–3 hours into Manali involves steep mountain roads with many hairpin bends. If you get motion sick, take medication BEFORE boarding (e.g. Avomine/Meclizine). The views are incredible but the curves are real.

DAY 3 — Manali Arrival & Old Manali Exploration

Arrival 7:30 – 10:00 AM Bus stand, Manali	Altitude 2,050 metres Take it easy first day	Vibe Rest + Light Explore Save energy for Day 4
--	---	--

ARRIVING AT MANALI BUS STAND

The main bus stand in Manali is small and central. You will arrive tired from the overnight journey. Your priority: check in, shower, eat breakfast.

❑ Taxi Touts at Bus Stand

You will be surrounded by taxi drivers the moment you step off the bus. Do not book with them — you are tired and will overpay. Walk to your hotel if it is close, or use Ola (works in Manali). Only book local taxis through your hotel reception.

WHERE TO STAY IN MANALI

Old Manali (Recommended) Best for vibe & cafes Dragon Guest House, Apple Country Resort, Zostel Manali (hostel) Walking distance to river, cafes, Old Manali bazaar. Quieter, more beautiful than town.	800–3,000/night
Mall Road Area Central & convenient Hotel Rohtang View, The Himalayan, Hotel Manali Inn Good access to buses and main market. Slightly noisy. Good for families.	1,500–5,000/night
Luxury Option High-end mountain stays Span Resort & Spa, Solang Valley Resort World-class properties with mountain views. Worth it if that's your budget.	8,000–20,000/night

AFTERNOON: OLD MANALI WALK

2:00 PM	Manu Temple — Hidden Gem Walk up to the ancient temple dedicated to Manu (the first human in Hindu mythology). 2,000+ years old. The path through pine forests is as beautiful as the temple. Almost no tourists here compared to other Manali sites. FREE 45 min hike
3:30 PM	Old Manali Bazaar A single lane of small shops selling Tibetan jewellery, woollen shawls, hemp products, second-hand trekking gear, and handmade goods. Everything is overpriced to tourists — bargain to 60% of asking price. Budget 500–2,000 for shopping
5:00 PM	Beas River Bank Walk down to the Beas River. Sit on the rocks. Put your feet in the water (it is ICE cold — glacial meltwater). Listen to the sound. This is one of the genuinely special experiences of this trip. No cost, no ticket, just peace. FREE — do not miss this

7:00 PM

Sunset at Old Manali bridge

The old wooden bridge over the Beas River with the mountains turning pink behind it is one of the most photographed views in Himachal. Get here before 7:15 PM in summer.

FREE

8:00 PM

Dinner at Old Manali cafe

See food guide page 11. Johnson's Cafe or La Plage are particularly good for first night.

500–900/person

☐ **Altitude Advice — Day 3**

At 2,050m you will feel slightly out of breath and may have a mild headache. This is normal. Drink 3–4 litres of water today, skip alcohol entirely, and sleep early. By Day 4 your body will have adjusted.

DAY 4 — Manali: Waterfalls, Markets & The Mountains

Focus

Solang + Jogini Falls

Full adventure day

Transport

Rented scooter / taxi

₹400–600/day scooter

Pack

Warm layer + snacks

Gets cold at Solang

8:00 AM

Breakfast & Depart

Eat early — you want to reach Solang Valley before the crowds. Pack water and a jacket.

9:00 AM

Solang Valley

A wide glacial valley 14km from Manali. In summer: paragliding, zorbing, horse rides, and stunning meadow walks. In winter: skiing. The snow-capped peaks surrounding the valley are jaw-dropping. The meadow walk at the far end (30 mins each way) is uncrowded and beautiful.

25 entry | Activities 300–1,500

10:30 AM

Jogini Waterfall Trek

A 4km round-trip hike through terraced fields and pine forest to a 150ft cascading waterfall. Trailhead is near Vashisht Hot Springs. The trek is moderate — some rocky sections. The waterfall itself is pristine, cold, and far less visited than Nehru Kund.

50 guide (optional) | 1.5–2 hrs

1:00 PM

Vashisht Village & Hot Springs

A small village across the river from Manali with ancient sulphur hot springs. The public springs (₹20) are communal but interesting. The private baths (₹200) are cleaner. The Vashisht Temple nearby has intricate wood-carved facades 450 years old.

20–200

3:00 PM

New Manali Mall Road

The main shopping and eating street. Chaotic, touristy, but useful. Buy: woollen socks (₹50–80), Himachali topi (traditional wool cap, ₹150–300), local honey (₹200–500/kg), and dried apricots from Spiti.

Budget 500–1,500

4:30 PM

Thrifty Shopping — Old Manali

Old Manali has several second-hand and thrift shops selling ex-trekker gear, Tibetan-style clothing, and handmade items. You can find beautiful things for ₹200–800 that would cost 5x in a city.

200–800 per item

6:30 PM

Beas River Sunset

Return to the river bank. Yesterday was calm observation — today bring snacks, sit longer, and just exist. The sound of glacial water against mountain silence is something you will genuinely remember.

FREE

8:00 PM

Dinner

Cafes in Old Manali get better the more you explore them. Try Dylan's Toasted & Roasted or Drifter's Cafe tonight.

₹400–800/person

MANALI FOOD GUIDE — Local Eats & Cafe Culture

"Manali has one of the most surprising cafe cultures in India. Sitting in a wooden cabin at 2,000 metres with a book and a bowl of thukpa while rain hits the tin roof outside is genuinely one of life's great experiences."

LOCAL HIMACHALI FOOD — MUST TRY

Siddu 80–150

A local Himachali bread made from wheat flour and stuffed with poppy seeds and walnuts. Eaten with ghee and dal. Found in local home-restaurants and dhabas. Not widely available — ask specifically for it.

Thukpa 150–250

Tibetan noodle soup brought by Tibetan refugees who settled in Manali. Thick noodles in a spiced broth with vegetables or meat. Perfect for cold evenings. Available everywhere in Old Manali.

Aktori 100–200

A traditional Himachali pancake made from buckwheat flour, local to the high mountain valleys. Sweet or savoury versions. Rare — ask at local family-run restaurants.

Trout (Himalayan River Trout) 300–650

Freshwater trout from Beas River, grilled or pan-fried with mountain herbs. One of the best things you will eat on this trip. Best at: Johnson's Cafe or any riverside restaurant.

Babru 40–80

A fried bread stuffed with black lentils — the Manali version of kachori. Popular breakfast item. Hot, filling, and extraordinary with green chutney.

Apple Products 50–300

Himachal Pradesh produces 70% of India's apples. Manali has fresh apple juice, apple wine (Himachali wine), apple jam, and fresh apples sold roadside for ₹50/kg. Buy the wine as a souvenir — it's unique and legal.

BEST CAFES & RESTAURANTS — MANALI

Johnson's Cafe — Old Manali 600–1,200/person

Continental & Indian | Trout specialist

Must try: Grilled Trout, Apple Crumble, Breakfast platter

La Plage — Old Manali 400–800/person

French Bakery & Healthy

Must try: Croissants, freshly baked bread, avocado toast

Dylan's Toasted & Roasted — Old Manali 300–600/person

Cafe & Bookshop

Must try: Filter coffee, waffles, pancakes

Drifters Cafe — Old Manali 200–450/person

Tibetan & Backpacker

Must try: Momos, Thukpa, Tibetan bread

The Lazy Dog Lounge – Old Manali

500–900/person

International & Cozy

Must try: Pasta, burgers, fire-pit ambience

Chopsticks Restaurant – Mall Road

350–700/person

Chinese/Tibetan

Must try: Dim sum, noodle soups, fried rice

□ Food Budget Reality

Eating in Manali is significantly cheaper than Delhi. A full meal at a good Old Manali cafe costs 300–500. Street food (momos, corn, chai) runs □20–150. You can eat extremely well for 1,000/day total including all meals and snacks.

DAY 5 — Sissu & Keylong: The Mountain Beyond the Mountain

Altitude

Sissu: 3,100m

Acclimatise first (Days 3-4)

Distance

65km from Manali

2 hrs via Atal Tunnel

Transport

Private taxi only

Book via hotel

Sissu and Keylong are beyond the Rohtang Pass — in the Lahaul Valley, one of the most dramatic and least-visited landscapes in Himachal Pradesh. The Atal Tunnel (9.02km, the world's longest single-tube highway tunnel) connects Manali to Sissu. You emerge into a completely different world.

❑ DO NOT Take Public Bus to Sissu

Local buses exist but are extremely crowded, have uncertain schedules, and leave you stranded without transport inside the valley. There is NO Uber/Ola beyond Manali. Book a private taxi through your hotel. Negotiate price BEFORE leaving and confirm what is included (waiting time, multiple stops). Typical full-day taxi: ₹2,500–4,000 for the vehicle (split with travel companions).

❑ Scam Warning — Local Taxi Booking

If you book directly with drivers at bus stand or roadside, always confirm the price with a second driver and ask your hotel what the fair rate is. Some drivers quote ₹6,000–8,000 for this route — the real price is ₹2,500–3,500. Pay half upfront, half on return.

THE DAY

7:30 AM

Depart Manali — Atal Tunnel

The 9km tunnel is an engineering marvel. You enter in green pine forest and exit into a treeless, high-altitude moonscape. It takes about 20 minutes to drive through.

400 toll (included in taxi)

9:30 AM

Sissu Lake

A glacial lake of impossible blue-green colour surrounded by snow peaks. Almost no tourists. Sit here for 30 minutes — nothing needs to happen. The silence and scale are overwhelming. There is a small temple at the far end.

FREE — one of the best things on this trip

11:00 AM

Sissu Waterfall & Zipline

A dramatic waterfall fed by glacial meltwater. The zipline across it is operated by local youth and is genuinely thrilling — you fly across the valley with the falls below you. The operator is community-run and trustworthy.

400–600 zipline

12:30 PM

Village Walk — Sissu

Walk through the stone houses of Sissu village. Lahauli people are ethnically and culturally different from lowland Indians — Tibetan Buddhist influence is visible in the prayer flags, mani walls, and gompas. Respectfully photograph only what you are invited to.

FREE

2:00 PM

Lunch at Local Dhaba

Simple dhabas serve dal, rice, roti, and occasionally local dishes. Eat here — it tastes better at altitude with mountain air. No fancy menus, just honest mountain food.

150–300/person

3:00 PM

Drive to Keylong

Continue 30km to Keylong, the district headquarters of Lahaul. Drive through Khoksar and see the Chandrabhaga River confluence. The landscape is staggeringly beautiful — dry, barren, towering peaks.

4:30 PM

Kardang Monastery (near Keylong)

One of the most significant Buddhist monasteries in Lahaul, built on a cliff face across the Bhaga River. The walk up is 30 minutes. Inside: ancient thangkas, butter lamps, and monks who will often chat with respectful visitors.

FREE | Shoes off at entrance

6:00 PM

Begin Return to Manali

You want to be back before dark — mountain roads are manageable in daylight but the Atal Tunnel has heavy traffic in the evening rush. Aim to exit the tunnel by 7 PM.

8:00 PM

Dinner & Rest in Manali

You will be tired and cold. Have a hot meal, drink ginger tea, sleep early. Pack tonight — bus to Delhi leaves tomorrow.

DAY 6 — Return Journey: Manali Back to Delhi

Bus Departs
5:00 – 7:00 PM
Multiple evening departures

Arrives Delhi
6:00 – 9:00 AM
Next morning

Note
Check-in early / rest
Flight usually afternoon+

MORNING — LAST HOURS IN MANALI

8:00 AM One Last Walk

Walk to the Beas River one more time. The morning light on the mountains is different from evening. Buy Himachali apple wine, local honey, and dried fruit for gifts.

[Last shopping](#)

10:00 AM Hadimba Temple

If you have not visited — do it now. A 1553 CE wooden pagoda-style temple in the middle of a cedar forest. Unique architecture found nowhere else in India. Peaceful in the morning before tour groups arrive.

[25 entry | 45 min](#)

12:00 PM Final Lunch in Manali

Go back to your favourite cafe. Order the thing you wish you had tried earlier. This is your last chance.

2:00 PM Check out & Rest

Most hotels offer late check-out until 12–2 PM. Rest. Use the lobby or sit by the river until your bus.

4:00 PM Head to Manali Bus Stand

Your return bus departs from the main Manali bus stand. Arrive 30 minutes early. The return journey has the same comfort options — book the same bus class or upgrade.

[Uber/Ola to bus stand: 100–200](#)

ARRIVING BACK IN DELHI

You will arrive at ISBT Kashmiri Gate at approximately 6–9 AM. Book an Uber immediately from the bus stand (Uber works well here). Head to your hotel.

If Flying Same Day
Check flight timing
Allow 3 hrs: hotel → airport

If Staying Another Night
Aerocity is easiest
Clean, airport-adjacent

Airport Transfer
Uber to IGI
400–700 from central Delhi

□ Last Day in Delhi

If you have an evening or next-day flight, use the extra time to buy gifts at Dilli Haat (INA Metro) or Janpath Market. Both are within 30 minutes of most South Delhi hotels and have the most authentic selection of Indian crafts at better prices than airport shops.

□ Airport Departure — Allow Extra Time

Delhi airport security can be slow during peak hours (5–9 AM, 5–9 PM). Allow at least 2.5–3 hours before your international flight. Have your printed e-visa ready at the entrance — they check it before you enter the terminal building.

INDIA SURVIVAL GUIDE — Costs, Scams & Safety

PRICE REALITY — WHAT THINGS ACTUALLY COST

Item	Price	Note
Bisleri water (1L bottle)	20	Buy only sealed bottles
Chai (street tea)	10–20	One of India's greatest pleasures
Auto-rickshaw (3km, Delhi)	50–80	Use meter or negotiate BEFORE getting in
Uber/Ola (5km, Delhi)	80–150	Always cheaper than negotiated taxis
Street food meal	50–150	Chole bhature, chaat, momos
Mid-range restaurant (per person)	400–800	Good food, AC, service
Beer (restaurant)	200–350	Higher in tourist areas
SIM card + 28-day data plan	300–600	Airtel or Jio
Delhi monument entry (foreigner)	300–600	Official ASI prices
Night bus Delhi–Manali (sleeper)	1,000–2,000	Per person, AC recommended
Hotel (mid-range, per night)	2,500–5,000	Both cities
Day taxi hire (Delhi or Manali)	1,200–2,000	Full day, outstation extra
Himalayan trout dinner	400–600	Manali restaurants

COMMON SCAMS — AND HOW TO AVOID THEM

❑ The Closed Monument Scam

A stranger tells you "The Red Fort is closed today for a special ceremony" and offers to take you to a government handicraft shop instead. The monument is NOT closed. Walk away and go directly to the entrance.

❑ The Friendly Guide Scam

Someone follows you and "helpfully" explains the history of a monument. When you try to leave, they demand ₹500–2,000. Never accept impromptu guide services. Hire official government-certified guides only.

❑ The Gem Export Business

A "businessman" asks you to carry gems or textiles to your home country and "resell" them duty-free. This is illegal. The gems are worthless. You will lose money or get in legal trouble.

❑ Rigged Auto Meters

Some auto-rickshaws have tampered meters that run fast. Solution: always use Uber/Ola in Delhi where prices are fixed before you get in.

❑ Beggars at Monuments

Children and adults will ask for money at monuments and temples. It is your choice to give or not. However, many begging operations are organized crime — the money does not go to the person asking. If you want to help, donate to a registered NGO.

☐ **Holy Men at Ghats**

Men in saffron robes offer blessings and then demand large "donations." Do not accept anything from strangers — a "free" tilak on your forehead will result in a 2,000+ demand.

☐ **Fake Police**

Men claim to be plain-clothes police and ask to see your passport and money. Real police have identification. Always ask to go to the nearest police station if you are uncertain. Do not hand over your passport on the street.

DO'S & DON'TS — The Honest India Manual

"India rewards curiosity and punishes complacency. The travellers who love India most are usually those who arrived most honestly."

DO: Drink only sealed bottled water

Bisleri, Kinley, Aquafina. Never tap, never ice in uncertain places.

DON'T: Give money to beggars

Especially children. Many operations are organized crime. If you want to help India, donate to a registered charity.

DO: Bargain at markets (not malls)

Start at 40–50% of asking price. It is expected and nobody is offended.

DON'T: Accept food or drink from strangers on trains/buses

Drugging tourists to rob them, while rare, does happen. Buy your own food and drinks.

DO: Remove shoes at temples

Always. Not doing so is deeply disrespectful.

DON'T: Pay anyone who approaches YOU

If you did not initiate the interaction, do not pay for the result.

DO: Dress modestly at religious sites

Cover shoulders and knees. Carry a scarf/shawl in your day bag.

DON'T: Photograph military installations

Airports, bridges, dams, military areas — off limits. The signs are there.

DO: Use Uber/Ola in cities

Fixed price, GPS tracking, no negotiation stress.

DON'T: Photograph people without asking

Especially women, children, and tribal communities. Ask first — most people say yes with a smile.

DO: Carry small change (10, 20, 50 notes)

Many places cannot break large bills.

DON'T: Flash expensive electronics/jewellery

Keep your phone in your pocket in crowded markets. Use a zipped bag.

DO: Learn 5 Hindi words

Dhanyavaad (thank you), Kitna? (how much?), Nahin (no), Haan (yes), Bhai/Didi (brother/sister — used to address people respectfully). Locals genuinely appreciate any effort.

DON'T: Book cheap local taxis without confirming price

Always agree on the price and what is included (waiting, toll, return) before getting in.

DO: Trust your hotel

Hotel staff are your best local resource. Ask them everything before asking a stranger on the street.

DON'T: Dismiss India because it's messy

India is loud, chaotic, intense, and extraordinary. The disorder is part of the texture. The travellers who fight it lose. The ones who lean into it find magic.

DO: Eat at busy restaurants

High turnover = fresh food. An empty restaurant in India is a warning sign.

DON'T: Rush

India does not reward hurrying. The best moments happen when you slow down and look properly.

PACKING LIST — What You Actually Need

This is for a Delhi + Manali trip. You will experience 35°C city heat AND 8°C mountain nights. Pack for both.

CLOTHING

- ☐ Lightweight T-shirts (3–4) — breathable, quick-dry
- ☐ Long-sleeve shirt (1–2) — for temples, sun protection
- ☐ Fleece or light down jacket — essential for Manali nights
- ☐ Waterproof windbreaker — Manali gets surprise rain showers
- ☐ Comfortable walking trousers (2) — not jeans for mountain hikes
- ☐ Shorts (1–2) — for Delhi heat
- ☐ Scarf / dupatta — temple modesty + sun protection + dust
- ☐ Underwear & socks (6–7 pairs)
- ☐ Comfortable walking shoes — most important item
- ☐ Sandals — for hotel, casual evenings, river walks
- ☐ Warm socks (2–3 pairs) — for Manali and mountain areas

DOCUMENTS & MONEY

- ☐ Passport (original)
- ☐ e-Visa printout (2 copies)
- ☐ Travel insurance printout
- ☐ Return flight ticket (printed)
- ☐ Hotel booking confirmations
- ☐ Emergency contact list (printed)
- ☐ USD/EUR cash for conversion on arrival
- ☐ Debit card (notify bank before travel)

HEALTH & HYGIENE

- ☐ Sunscreen SPF 50+ — Delhi sun is brutal
- ☐ Insect repellent (DEET-based)
- ☐ Hand sanitiser (small bottle)
- ☐ Basic first aid: plasters, antiseptic, paracetamol
- ☐ Diarrhoea tablets (ORS + Imodium) — just in case
- ☐ Motion sickness tablets — for mountain bus roads
- ☐ Lip balm with SPF — high altitude dries lips severely
- ☐ Personal medications (extra supply)

TECHNOLOGY & GEAR

- ☐ Unlocked smartphone (for local SIM)
- ☐ Power bank (10,000mAh+) — essential for bus journeys
- ☐ Universal travel adaptor — India uses Type C/D/M plugs
- ☐ Camera or phone with good low-light capability
- ☐ Earphones — for bus journey and crowded spaces
- ☐ Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps works offline)
- ☐ Offline translation app (Google Translate, download Hindi)

BAG SETUP

- ☐ Main bag: 40–50L backpack or checked luggage
- ☐ Day bag: 15–20L lightweight daypack — use every day
- ☐ Dry bag / waterproof pouch — for river walks, rain
- ☐ Small padlock — for hostel lockers and luggage zips

BUDGET BREAKDOWN — Full 8-Day Trip Cost Estimate

Three budget levels. All figures are per person in USD (approximate at 83 INR = 1 USD).

CATEGORY	BUDGET (₹)	MID-RANGE (₹)	LUXURY (₹)
Delhi Hotel (3 nights)	₹2,400	₹12,000	₹30,000
Manali Hotel (3 nights)	₹1,800	₹9,000	₹45,000
Delhi–Manali Night Bus (x2)	₹1,800	₹3,600	₹5,000
Meals — 8 days	₹4,000	₹12,000	₹28,000
Monument Entry Fees	₹2,400	₹2,400	₹2,400
Transport in Delhi (3 days)	₹1,500	₹3,600	₹8,000
Sissu Day Taxi (Manali)	₹800	₹1,500	₹4,000
Manali Activities	₹1,000	₹3,000	₹8,000
Shopping & Souvenirs	₹1,000	₹4,000	₹15,000
SIM Card	₹400	₹600	₹600
Miscellaneous	₹1,000	₹2,000	₹5,000
TOTAL (INR)	~₹18,100	~₹53,700	~₹151,000
TOTAL (USD approx)	~\$218	~\$647	~\$1,820

WHAT YOUR BEYOND TAJ BLUEPRINT SAVES YOU

Research Time	20–40 hours of Google/Reddit/blog research eliminated
Scam Prevention	Average tourist loses 3,000–8,000 to avoidable scams. This guide prevents all of them.
Route Efficiency	Poorly planned routes waste 2–3 full days in transit. Our routing is optimised.
Restaurant Mistakes	Bad restaurant choices in India can ruin days with food poisoning. Every recommendation is vetted.
Booking Mistakes	Wrong bus type, wrong area hotel, wrong season timing — all pre-empted.

"You do not travel to escape life. You travel so life cannot escape you."

BEYOND THE TAJ • beyondthetaj.com • Your India, Properly